POLYTECHNIQUE MONTRÉAL
affiliée à l'Université de Montréal

A lightweight canonicalization engine in C

WILLIAM ZHANG
Département de Electrical Engineering

Mémoire présenté en vue de l'obtention du diplôme de *Maîtrise ès sciences appliquées*
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A lightweight canonicalization engine in C

présenté par **William ZHANG**
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Danielle DUBOIS, présidente
Sébastien VIGOT, membre et directeur de recherche
Marie COUTURE, membre et codirectrice de recherche
Jean TREMBLAY, membre
Joseph BROWN, membre externe

DEDICATION

À tous mes amis du labos,
vous me manquerez...

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Texte / Text.

RÉSUMÉ

Le résumé est un bref exposé du sujet traité, des objectifs visés, des hypothèses émises, des méthodes expérimentales utilisées et de l'analyse des résultats obtenus. On y présente également les principales conclusions de la recherche ainsi que ses applications éventuelles. En général, un résumé ne dépasse pas trois pages.

Le résumé doit donner une idée exacte du contenu du mémoire ou de la thèse. Ce ne peut pas être une simple énumération des parties du manuscrit. Le but est de présenter de façon précise et concise la nature, l'envergure de la recherche, les sujets traités, les questions de recherche ou les hypothèses soulevées, les méthodes utilisées, les principaux résultats ainsi que les conclusions retenues. Un résumé ne doit jamais comporter de références ou de figures.

ABSTRACT

Written in English, the abstract is a brief summary similar to the previous section (Résumé). However, this section is not a word for word translation of the abstract in French.

The abstract is a brief statement of the subject matter, objectives, research questions or hypotheses, experimental methods and analysis of results. It also presents the main research conclusions and their possible applications. In general, an abstract should not exceed three pages.

The abstract should provide an exact idea of the thesis or dissertation's contents and it cannot be a simple enumeration of the manuscript's parts. The goal is to precisely and concisely present the nature and scope of the research. An abstract should never include references or figures. If the thesis or the dissertation is in English, the résumé (French-language abstract) should come first followed by the abstract.

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LIST OF SYMBOLS AND ACRONYMS

AD	Automatic Differentiation
AML	Algebraic Modeling Language
CSC	Compressed Sparse Column
CSR	Compressed Sparse Row
DAG	Directed Acyclic Graph
DCP	Disciplined Convex Programming
LP	Linear Program
MOI	MathOptInterface
MPS	Mathematical Programming System
NLP	Nonlinear Program
QP	Quadratic Program
SOCP	Second-Order Cone Program
SDP	Semidefinite Program

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CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

Modeling languages for convex optimization such as CVXPY [1] and YALMIP [2] allow users to formulate optimization problems in a natural mathematical syntax. Through a process called *canonicalization*, these high-level problem descriptions are converted to a *standard conic form* used by many general-purpose solvers

$$\begin{array}{ll} \text{minimize} & c^T x \\ \text{subject to} & Ax + s = b \\ & s \in K, \end{array} \tag{1.1}$$

where $x \in \mathbf{R}^n$ and $s \in \mathbf{R}^m$ are the decision variables, and the *problem data* are the matrix $A \in \mathbf{R}^{m \times n}$, the vectors $b \in \mathbf{R}^m$ and $c \in \mathbf{R}^n$, and the non-empty closed convex cone $K \subseteq \mathbf{R}^m$. Almost all of optimization practice can be divided into two groups, modeling and solving. The modeler's role is to [...]. The solver's role is to find an optimal solution given a problem data instance. Modeling languages serve as the communication bridge between these two groups. When improvements in solvers are made, modeling languages must adapt to allow users to benefit from them. Conversely, it is through natural formulations that modelers can express their needs and help motivate solver improvements.

While the time taken to solve an optimization problem is often dominated by the solver, the time taken to *canonicalize* (or *compile*) a problem can also be significant, especially for large problems. In the case of CVXPY, the *compilation time* largely lies in *matrix stuffing*, the final step of canonicalization where symbolic expressions trees are converted to explicit numerical matrices. Other modeling languages take different approaches to form the problem data, we refer to their approaches as *coefficient extraction* and review them in §2.3.

Matrix stuffing. After expanding nonlinear functions into their *graph implementations* [3], all expressions trees are guaranteed to be affine. We review the entire canonicalization process and show a concrete example in §2.1. At this stage, the convex cone $\mathcal{K}$, which is typically a cartesian product of *standard cones*, is already computed and known. The remaining problem data are the *constraint matrix* A and the vectors b and c. The process to compute b is relatively straightforward, for example, one can *evaluate* the affine expression tree at the origin. The process to obtain c is a special case of the process to obtain A. For these reasons, we will often refer to matrix stuffing as the explicit task of forming A. We review matrix stuffing and its current implementations in CVXPY in §2.2.

Contributions. We make the following contributions:

1. We develop `SparseDiffEngine`.
2. We develop `SparseDiffPy`.
3. We benchmark our methods against existing approaches.

All code is open source and available at `https://github.com/SparseDifferentiation/`.

Thesis outline. The rest of this thesis is organized as follows. In §2 we review the literature on modeling languages, canonicalization, and matrix stuffing. In §3 we describe our proposed canonicalization engine. In §4 we present benchmark results comparing our method to existing approaches. Finally, in §6 we summarize our contributions and discuss future work.

CHAPTER 2 LITERATURE REVIEW

Solving an optimization problem on a computer requires translating the mathematical formulation into a data format that solvers can process. For linear programs, this means constructing the constraint matrix A, the right-hand side vector b, and the objective coefficients c that define the *standard form*,

$$\begin{aligned} \text{minimize} \quad & c^T x \\ \text{subject to} \quad & Ax \leq b, \\ & x \geq 0. \end{aligned} \tag{2.1}$$

Manual encoding In the early days of linear programming, analysts manually computed and encoded each coefficient onto punch cards. This process was tedious, error-prone and became impractical as linear programming found more and more applications in large-scale industrial problems [4].

MPS format IBM's Mathematical Programming System (MPS) file format, developed in the 1960s, established a standardized file format for representing linear programs [5]. The MPS format uses fixed-width fields designed for 80-column punch cards, with sections for rows, columns, and coefficients. William Orchard-Hays [6] provides a comprehensive history of these early mathematical programming systems, tracing their development from 1952 at RAND Corporation through their widespread adoption on mainframe computers in the late 1960s.

Matrix generators To automate the creation of MPS files, *matrix generators* emerged in the late 1960s; they are procedural programs that compute the problem coefficients through explicit loops and output the results in MPS format [7]. Commercial systems such as `MaGen` [8], `GAMMA` [9], and `DATAFORM` [10] were among the first matrix generators which were used in various domains.

2.1 Canonicalization

2.2 Matrix stuffing

2.3 Coefficient extraction

`JuMP` and `MathOptInterface`.

`CasADi`.

`AMPL`.

2.4 Computing derivatives

Automatic differentiation. [?] [?] [?]

Symbolic differentiation. [?]

Sparse differentiation.

Other methods.

2.5 Sparse matrix formats

Matrices that contain many number of zero entries are known as *sparse matrices*. The simplest sparse matrix data structure is the *coordinate* or *triplet* format. It consists of two integer index arrays `rows` and `cols` and a floating point value array `vals` of length equal to the number of *nonzero entries* in the matrix.

For example, the matrix

$$\begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 3.2 & 0 \\ 4.1 & 1.8 & 0 & 2.2 \\ 0 & 2.8 & 0 & 3.4 \end{bmatrix} \tag{2.2}$$

can be represented in coordinate format as

```
int    rows[] = {0,  1,   1,   1,   2,   2};
int    cols[] = {2,  0,   1,   3,   1,   3};
double vals[] = {3.2, 4.1, 1.8, 2.2, 2.8, 3.4};
```

where we use zero-based indexing and array declaration notation from the C programming language [11]. The coordinate format is the easiest to understand and form, but it is not effective for most operations on sparse matrices; the *compressed sparse row* or CSR format is commonly used instead.

Compressed sparse row format. The CSR format differs from the coordinate format in that it replaces the `rows` array with a row pointer array `idxptr` of length equal to the number of rows plus one. The row pointer array indicates the starting index of each row in the `cols` arrays. For example, the matrix in (2.2) can be represented in CSR format as

```
int  idxptr[] = {0,  1,              4,        6};
int    cols[] = {2,  0,   1,   3,    1,   3};
double vals[] = {3.2, 4.1, 1.8, 2.2, 2.8, 3.4};
```

where we deliberately format `idxptr` to align with the start of each row in the `cols` arrays. The benefits of the CSR format are more than compressed storage for the `idxptr` array compared to the `rows` arrays. In the CSR format, accessing a row takes constant time and is very *cache-friendly* since the nonzero entries are stored contiguously in memory. For this reason, the CSR format is the default for *iterative methods* to solve sparse linear systems [12].

However, one downside of the CSR format is that accessing a column is much more difficult; one would need to look at every row to find the nonzero entries in a column. An alternative format is the *compressed sparse column* or CSC format, which replaces the `idxptr` array with a column pointer array and the `cols` array with a `rows` array. In contrast to iterative methods, the CSC format is the preferred format for *direct methods* to solve sparse linear systems [13].

Other formats. The coordinate, CSR and CSC formats are the most widely used sparse matrix formats, but there are many other formats that are designed for other specific applications. The scientific python sparse linear algebra library `scipy.sparse` supports other formats such as the list of lists (LIL) format, the dictionary of keys (DOK) format, and the block-sparse row (BSR) format [14].

Converting between formats.

Resources. Although the work in this thesis does not revolve around solving sparse linear systems, a lot of techniques were inspired by the existing literature in the field. In particular, the book by Davis [13] was used extensively throughout the development of our methods. The

book by Duff [15] is another great reference to learn more about the history and developement of sparse matrix algorithms.

CHAPTER 3 A LIGHTWEIGHT COEFFICIENT EXTRACTION ENGINE

The previous chapter showed that coefficient extraction in modern modeling languages relies on generic sparse matrix multiplication—an approach that creates intermediate matrices at every node of the expression tree and treats each linear operator as an arbitrary sparse matrix. This chapter presents an alternative: a lightweight engine written in C that operates directly on CSR index arrays, avoiding intermediate matrices entirely.

3.1 Design principles

The engine is guided by three principles, each addressing a specific inefficiency identified in the previous chapter's analysis of existing systems.

Principle 1: Direct CSR rewriting Every affine atom transforms the CSR arrays `(indptr, indices, data)` of the child's Jacobian directly, rather than forming an operator matrix and composing via sparse matrix multiplication. A `sum` node merges row pointers; a `left_matmul` node applies block-diagonal dot products; an `index` node copies row segments. No intermediate sparse matrices are formed at any point.

Principle 2: Two-phase evaluation Sparsity patterns are computed once at build time (*init phase*); numerical values are filled at solve time (*eval phase*). The init phase traverses the expression tree bottom-up, determining the exact number of nonzeros in each Jacobian and allocating all arrays to their final sizes. The eval phase traverses the same tree, filling values into pre-allocated arrays without any allocation. This separation mirrors the compile-once, evaluate-many paradigm used in parametric optimisation.

Principle 3: Precomputed index mappings Where rows must be combined, reordered, or selected, a mapping from source to destination positions is precomputed during init. At eval time, the operation reduces to a single $O(\texttt{nnz})$ scatter loop. The `sum` atom's `idx_map` array (Section 3.3.2) is the prototypical example: rather than performing a sparse matrix multiplication $\mathbf{1}^T J_x$ at every evaluation, the engine scatters the child's nonzeros through a fixed map.

3.1.1 Architecture overview

The engine represents each affine expression as a node in a directed acyclic graph (DAG). Each node is a C `struct` containing:

- the node's *type* (one of the fifteen atoms in Table 3.1),
- a pair of function pointers—`jacobian_init` and `eval_jacobian`—that implement the two-phase protocol for that atom type,
- pointers to child nodes (one or two, depending on the atom),
- the Jacobian in CSR format: arrays `indptr`, `indices`, and `data`, plus dimensions,
- atom-specific auxiliary data (index maps, constant matrices, axis parameters).

Function-pointer dispatch on the node type provides polymorphism without virtual-table overhead.

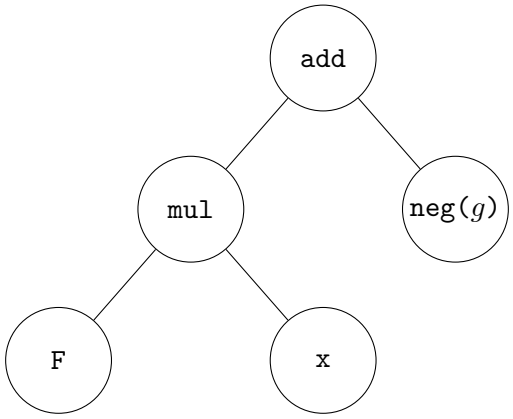
When two expressions share a common subexpression, the DAG representation allows the shared node's Jacobian to be computed once and reused by both parents. The engine tracks whether each node's Jacobian has been evaluated via a `jacobian_called` flag, avoiding redundant computation.

A *problem container* groups the objective expression and all constraint expressions, manages the global variable ordering, and stores the final assembled coefficient matrices (A, b, c) that are handed to the solver.

3.2 Worked example: tracing coefficient extraction

To build intuition before the atom-by-atom treatment, we trace the least-squares problem minimize $\|Fx - g\|_2^2$ from Chapter 2 end-to-end through the engine. After canonicalization (DCP verification, Smith form, and relaxed Smith form as described in Section 2), the conic reformulation produces the equality constraint $t = Fx - g$ linking the auxiliary variable t to the original expression. The engine must extract the coefficient matrix for this affine expression.

Expression tree after canonicalization The affine expression $Fx - g$ is represented as:



The `mul` node represents left multiplication by the constant matrix $F \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 2}$, the `neg` node negates the constant $g \in \mathbf{R}^3$, and the `add` node sums the two children.

Init phase The engine traverses the tree bottom-up, computing sparsity patterns:

1. **Variable leaf** (x): Jacobian is I_2 (identity), so `nnz` $= 2$, `indptr` $= [0, 1, 2]$, `indices` $= [0, 1]$.
2. **`mul` node** ($F \cdot x$): The Jacobian with respect to x is F itself, a 3×2 matrix. Init determines `nnz` $= 6$ (all entries of F are nonzero) and allocates arrays of the corresponding sizes.
3. **Constant leaf** ($-g$): No variable dependence, contributes only to the constant column. Jacobian with respect to x is the 3×2 zero matrix.
4. **`add` node**: Takes the union of the children's sparsity patterns. Since the constant $-g$ contributes no variable columns, the output sparsity matches the `mul` child: `nnz` $= 6$.

After init, every node's CSR arrays are allocated to their exact final sizes. No further allocation occurs.

Eval phase A second bottom-up traversal fills in numerical values:

1. **Variable leaf**: `data` $= [1, 1]$ (identity values).
2. **`mul` node**: Applies F to the child's Jacobian via block-diagonal dot products (Section 3.3.3), writing the six entries of F into `data`.
3. **`add` node**: Sums corresponding entries. The constant offset $-g$ is added to the constant column of the output.

Result The root node's Jacobian is the coefficient matrix:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} x_1 & x_2 & 1 \\ \left[\begin{array}{cc|c} 1 & 2 & -1 \\ 3 & 4 & -2 \\ 5 & 6 & -3 \end{array}\right] & = [F \mid -g], \end{array}$$

which matches the constraint $t - Fx = -g$ from the canonicalization. The entire computation involved no sparse matrix multiplication, no intermediate matrix allocation, and no runtime sparsity discovery.

3.3 Affine atoms

Table 3.1 catalogues the fifteen affine atoms implemented in the engine. Each atom exposes two entry points: `jacobian_init`, which determines the output Jacobian's sparsity pattern once at problem-build time, and `eval_jacobian`, which fills in the numerical values each time parameters change. The table's third column summarises the key CSR manipulation performed by each atom.

Table 3.1 Catalogue of affine atoms. Each row describes one node type, its mathematical operation, and the core CSR transformation applied to the child's Jacobian during `eval_jacobian`.

Atom	Math operation	Jacobian action on CSR
`variable`	$y = x$	Identity (leaf node)
`parameter`	$y = \theta$	None (data node)
`linear_op`	$y = Ax + b$	$J = A$ (stored directly)
`add`	$y = a + b$	Union sparsity, sum values
`neg`	$y = -x$	Same sparsity, negate `data`
`sum`	$y = \sum x$ (along axis)	Merge rows via `idx_map`
`hstack`	$y = [a; b; \ldots]$	Concatenate row blocks
`index`	$y = x[\text{idx}]$	Select/reorder rows
`reshape`	$\text{reshape}(x, m, n)$	No-op (copy arrays)
`transpose`	$y = X^T$	Permute rows
`broadcast`	$(1, n) \to (m, n)$	Tile/replicate rows
`promote`	scalar $\to$ vector	Replicate single row
`trace`	$y = \mathbf{Tr}(X)$	Sum diagonal rows via `idx_map`
`diag_vec`	$v \to \mathbf{diag}(v)$	Place rows at diagonal positions
`left_matmul`	$y = A \cdot f(x)$	Block-diagonal multiply (no Kronecker)

The subsections that follow first describe the general principle of encoding linear operators directly on CSR arrays, then examine three representative atoms in detail: `sum` (Section 3.3.2),

which illustrates the `idx_map` accumulation trick; `left_matmul` (Section 3.3.3), which avoids forming a Kronecker product; and `index` (Section 3.3.4), which performs pure structural row selection with no arithmetic.

3.3.1 Direct encoding of linear operators

Rather than composing operators via sparse matrix multiplication, we keep the coefficient matrix in CSR (Compressed Sparse Row) format and directly manipulate its index arrays without forming intermediate matrices. Each linear operator is implemented as a transformation on the CSR arrays `(indptr, indices, data)`. For example, the `sum` operator collapses all rows into row 0 by setting all entries of `indptr` to $[0, \texttt{nnz}]$, effectively mapping every row index to 0 without any matrix multiplication.

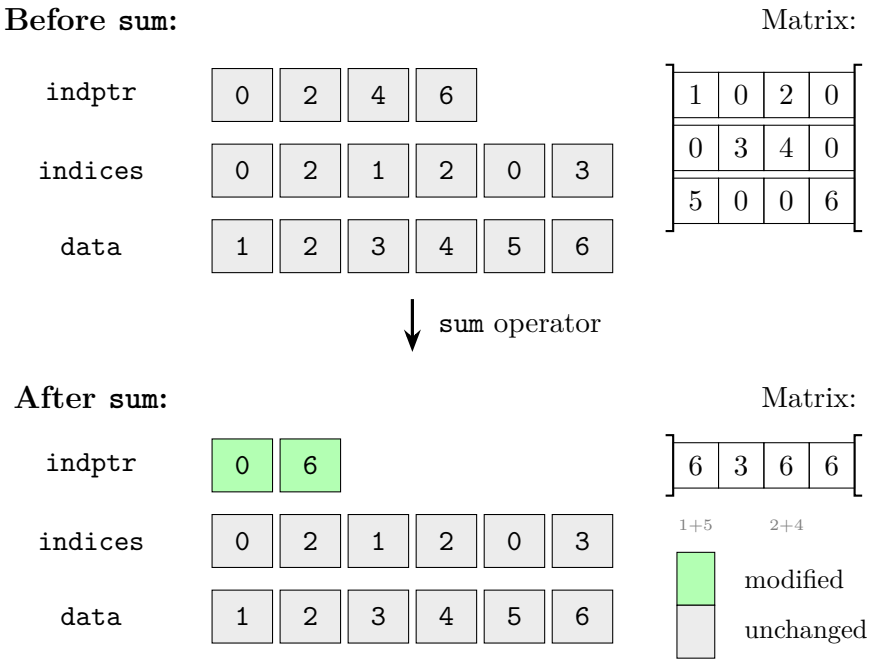


Figure 3.1 CSR representation before and after applying `sum`. The 3-row matrix collapses to 1 row by setting `indptr` $= [0, 6]$. Duplicate column indices (0 and 2) represent values that sum together. The `indices` and `data` arrays remain unchanged—no matrix multiplication required.

3.3.2 The `sum` atom and the `idx_map` trick

Summing along an axis collapses multiple rows of the child's Jacobian into fewer rows. Mathematically, for a full summation ($y = \mathbf{1}^T x$, scalar output), the Jacobian is $J_y = \mathbf{1}^T J_{\text{child}}$—every row of J_{child} is accumulated into a single output row. The naïve approach would compute

this via sparse matrix multiplication, allocating a new matrix each time. Instead, the engine precomputes a mapping from every nonzero position in the child's Jacobian to its target position in the output, then uses a simple scatter-accumulate loop at evaluation time.

Initialisation (Algorithm 1) During `jacobian_init`, the output sparsity pattern is determined by taking the union of all column indices that appear across the rows being summed. Duplicate column indices from different rows are merged into a single output entry. An array `idx_map` of length $\texttt{nnz}(J_{\text{child}})$ is then built: for each nonzero k in the child's Jacobian, $\texttt{idx_map}[k]$ stores the position in the output's `data` array where that value should be accumulated.

Algorithm 1 `sum` — Jacobian initialisation (sparsity + index map)

Require: Child Jacobian J_x in CSR format; rows to sum: $\{r_0, \ldots, r_{s-1}\}$
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with one row per output element; array `idx_map`

1: *cols* $\leftarrow$ union of column indices across summed rows of J_x
2: Sort *cols*; remove duplicates ▷ $O(\texttt{nnz} \log \texttt{nnz})$
3: Set J.`indptr`, J.`indices` from *cols*
4: Build reverse map `col_to_pos`[ ]: for each unique column c at position p, set $\texttt{col_to_pos}[c] \leftarrow p$
5: **for** each nonzero k in J_x (across summed rows) **do**
6: $\quad \texttt{idx_map}[k] \leftarrow \texttt{col_to_pos}[J_x.\texttt{indices}[k]]$
7: **end for**

Evaluation (Algorithm 2) At each parameter update, `eval_jacobian` zeroes the output values and then scatters the child's nonzeros through the precomputed map. The loop body is a single indexed addition per nonzero—no sorting, no allocation, and no matrix multiply.

Algorithm 2 `sum` — Jacobian evaluation

Require: Child Jacobian J_x (values updated); precomputed `idx_map`
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with accumulated values

1: $J.\texttt{data} \leftarrow \mathbf{0}$
2: **for** $k = 0$ **to** $\texttt{nnz}(J_x) - 1$ **do**
3: $\quad J.\texttt{data}[\texttt{idx_map}[k]] \mathrel{+}= J_x.\texttt{data}[k]$
4: **end for**

Complexity Initialisation costs $O(\texttt{nnz} \log \texttt{nnz})$ (dominated by the sort) and runs once. Evaluation costs $O(\texttt{nnz})$ with a single pass over the child's nonzeros. While sparse matrix multiplication $\mathbf{1}^T J_x$ is also $O(\texttt{nnz})$ in principle, it must allocate a new result matrix, compute

its sparsity pattern, and sort indices at every call—overhead that the `idx_map` approach eliminates entirely. Figure 3.1 illustrates the CSR transformation for a concrete example.

3.3.3 The `left_matmul` atom and Kronecker avoidance

Left multiplication computes $Y = A\,X$ where $A \in \mathbf{R}^{m\times n}$ is a constant (or parameter) matrix and $X \in \mathbf{R}^{n\times p}$ is the child expression. Writing the operation in vectorised form gives

$$\mathbf{vec}(Y) = (I_p \otimes A)\ \mathbf{vec}(X), \tag{3.1}$$

so the Jacobian with respect to $\mathbf{vec}(X)$ is the block-diagonal matrix $I_p \otimes A$ of size $mp \times np$. Forming this Kronecker product explicitly would require storing $p \cdot \mathtt{nnz}(A)$ entries in the best case; worse, composing it with the child's Jacobian via sparse matrix multiplication is $O(p^2 \cdot \mathtt{nnz}(A))$ in general.

The engine avoids the Kronecker product entirely by exploiting the block-diagonal structure. It stores only A (of size $m \times n$) and applies it independently to each of the p column-blocks of the child's Jacobian. The computation is carried out in CSC (Compressed Sparse Column) format, because the child's Jacobian columns each decompose naturally into p consecutive blocks of n rows.

Initialisation During `jacobian_init`, the child's Jacobian sparsity is converted to CSC. For each column j and each block $b \in \{0, \ldots, p-1\}$, the engine identifies which rows of A have overlapping column support with the child's nonzeros in block b. These overlaps determine the output sparsity without ever forming $I_p \otimes A$.

Evaluation (Algorithm 3) At each parameter update, the child's Jacobian values are converted to CSC, then each output nonzero is computed as a sparse dot product of a row of A with the corresponding block-slice of the child's column.

Complexity Let $\bar{k}$ denote the average number of nonzeros per column of J_{child} within a single block. Each output nonzero requires a sparse dot product of cost at most $O(\mathtt{nnz_row}(A) + \bar{k})$. The total work is therefore $O(\mathtt{nnz}(J) \cdot (\mathtt{nnz_row}(A) + \bar{k}))$, which for typical sparse problems is far smaller than the $O(p^2 \cdot \mathtt{nnz}(A))$ cost of forming and multiplying the Kronecker product.

Algorithm 3 `left_matmul` — Jacobian evaluation (block-diagonal multiply)

Require: Constant matrix $A \in \mathbf{R}^{m \times n}$; child Jacobian J_x in CSC with p column-blocks of n rows; precomputed output sparsity J in CSC
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with filled values

Convert J_x values from CSR to CSC ▷ pattern already fixed
for each column j of J **do**
  for each block $b = 0, \ldots, p-1$ **do**
    $S \leftarrow$ nonzeros of J_x column j in rows $[b \cdot n,\ (b+1) \cdot n)$
    for each output nonzero $(b \cdot m + i,\ j)$ in J **do**
      $J.\texttt{data}[\cdot] \leftarrow \text{sparse_dot}(A[i, :],\ S)$
    end for
  end for
end for
Convert J values from CSC to CSR

3.3.4 The `index` atom and structural row selection

Indexing selects a subset of elements from the child expression: $y = x[\text{indices}]$. Its Jacobian is a row-selection matrix P whose rows are drawn from the identity—row i of P is row indices$[i]$ of I. Since the child's Jacobian is stored in CSR, selecting rows amounts to copying contiguous segments of the `indices` and `data` arrays guided by `indptr`. No arithmetic is performed at all.

Initialisation (Algorithm 4) During `jacobian_init`, the output Jacobian's sparsity pattern is constructed by copying the column-index segment of each selected row from the child's Jacobian. The row pointer array `indptr` is built incrementally.

Algorithm 4 `index` — Jacobian initialisation (structural copy)

Require: Child Jacobian J_x in CSR; selection array $\texttt{idx}[0 \ldots k-1]$
Ensure: Output Jacobian J in CSR with selected rows

$J.\texttt{indptr}[0] \leftarrow 0$
for $i = 0$ **to** $k - 1$ **do**
  $r \leftarrow \texttt{idx}[i]$ ▷ source row in J_x
  $\ell \leftarrow J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r+1] - J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r]$
  Copy $J_x.\texttt{indices}[J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] \ldots J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] + \ell)$ into $J.\texttt{indices}[J.\texttt{indptr}[i] \ldots]$
  $J.\texttt{indptr}[i+1] \leftarrow J.\texttt{indptr}[i] + \ell$
end for
$J.\texttt{nnz} \leftarrow J.\texttt{indptr}[k]$

Evaluation (Algorithm 5) At each parameter update, `eval_jacobian` copies the `data` segments for the same selected rows. The sparsity pattern is identical to the child's selected rows, so only values move.

Algorithm 5 `index` — Jacobian evaluation (value copy)

Require: Child Jacobian J_x (values updated); selection array $\texttt{idx}[0 \dots k-1]$; output Jacobian J (pattern fixed)
Ensure: Output Jacobian J with copied values
1: **for** $i = 0$ **to** $k - 1$ **do**
2: $r \leftarrow \texttt{idx}[i]$
3: $\ell \leftarrow J.\texttt{indptr}[i+1] - J.\texttt{indptr}[i]$
4: Copy $J_x.\texttt{data}[J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] \dots J_x.\texttt{indptr}[r] + \ell)$ into $J.\texttt{data}[J.\texttt{indptr}[i] \dots]$
5: **end for**

Complexity Both initialisation and evaluation cost $O\Big(\sum_{i=0}^{k-1} \texttt{nnz}(\text{row}_{\texttt{idx}[i]})\Big)$, proportional to the total number of nonzeros in the selected rows. The operation involves no arithmetic—only `memcpy` calls—making it one of the cheapest atoms in the engine.

The preceding atom deep-dives illustrate the common pattern: each atom transforms the child's CSR arrays directly, using precomputed index mappings to eliminate runtime allocation and sparsity discovery. The remaining sections address the system-level concerns that complete the engine design.

3.4 Memory management

The two-phase design described in Section 3.1 enables tight control over memory allocation. This section describes the four techniques the engine uses to minimise memory overhead.

Exact-size allocation The init phase determines the exact number of nonzeros in every node's Jacobian before any numerical computation occurs. All `malloc` calls therefore allocate arrays of exactly the required size—no over-allocation, no reallocation, and no amortised-doubling strategies. For a tree with N nodes, init performs at most $3N$ allocations (one each for `indptr`, `indices`, and `data` per node), and eval performs zero.

Affine Jacobian caching Nodes whose children are all constants (no variable or parameter dependence) produce Jacobians that never change. The engine detects such nodes during init and marks them as *cached*: their `eval_jacobian` is called once, and subsequent evaluations skip them entirely. In typical problems, constant subexpressions (data matrices, fixed offsets)

constitute a significant fraction of the tree, so caching eliminates a proportional share of eval-time work.

No Python object overhead Because the engine is implemented in C, there is no `scipy.sparse` object creation, no Python reference counting or garbage collection pressure during evaluation, and no format-conversion copies between CSR and CSC. Each Jacobian is stored as three raw C arrays and a set of dimension fields. The total per-node overhead is a fixed-size `struct` plus the three arrays, compared to the multiple Python objects, type metadata, and indirection layers in a `scipy.sparse.csr_matrix`.

Memory footprint analysis The engine's total memory consumption for a single expression tree is:

$$M = \sum_{i=1}^{N} \Big((n_i{+}1)\cdot\texttt{sizeof(int)} + \texttt{nnz}_i \cdot (\texttt{sizeof(int)} + \texttt{sizeof(double)}) \Big) + N\cdot\texttt{sizeof(expr)},$$

where n_i is the number of rows and $\texttt{nnz}_i$ the number of nonzeros in node i's Jacobian. In `CVXPY`'s approach, each sparse matrix multiplication at node i temporarily allocates an additional result matrix, so the peak memory includes both the child's matrix and the product. The engine avoids this by writing directly into the pre-allocated output, so peak memory equals the sum above with no temporary overhead.

3.5 Parameter handling

When a problem contains parameters (symbolic placeholders whose numerical values change between solves), the engine must update the coefficient matrices without repeating the init phase. The two-phase architecture makes this straightforward.

Parameter lifecycle Parameters are registered during problem construction via `register_params`, which associates each parameter node in the expression tree with a pointer to the user-supplied value storage. When the user updates parameter values and requests a new solve, `update_params` copies the new values into the parameter nodes.

Lazy refresh via `jacobian_called` Each node carries a Boolean flag `jacobian_called`. After `update_params` is called, the engine resets this flag on every node that depends (transitively) on a changed parameter. The subsequent eval traversal then recomputes only the

affected nodes. Nodes that depend solely on constants retain their cached Jacobians and are not revisited.

Direct re-traversal Unlike `CVXPY`'s tensor-based parametric approach, which stores a three-dimensional structure mapping each parameter to its coefficient contributions, the engine simply re-traverses the expression tree with the new parameter values. This avoids the storage overhead of the tensor representation and reuses the same tree-walking infrastructure used for the initial evaluation.

Contrast with the tensor approach `CVXPY`'s `TensorView` maintains a dictionary of dictionaries: for each variable, for each parameter, a separate sparse matrix. For problems with p parameters and v variables, this multiplies the storage by up to $p \cdot v$. The engine's approach stores only one Jacobian per node regardless of the number of parameters. The trade-off is that a parameter update requires a full eval traversal rather than a single sparse matrix substitution, but since eval is dominated by $O(\texttt{nnz})$ scatter and copy operations, this cost is modest in practice.

CHAPTER 4 BENCHMARK RESULTS

CHAPTER 5 Benchmark results

CHAPTER 6 CONCLUSION

Texte / Text.

6.1 Synthèse des travaux / Summary of Works

Texte / Text.

6.2 Limitations de la solution proposée / Limitations

6.3 Améliorations futures / Future Research

Texte / Text.

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APPENDIX A DÉMO

Texte de l'annexe A. Remarquez que la phrase précédente se termine par une lettre majuscule suivie d'un point. On indique explicitement cette situation à LaTeX afin que ce dernier ajuste correctement l'espacement entre le point final de la phrase et le début de la phrase suivante.

APPENDIX B ENCORE UNE ANNEXE / ANOTHER APPENDIX

Texte de l'annexe B en mode «landscape».

APPENDIX C UNE DERNIÈRE ANNEXE / THE LAST APPENDIX

Texte de l'annexe C.